

Windows 11 Upgrade Guide

What Windows 10 users need to know

Microsoft ended normal support for Windows 10 on 14 October 2025. Windows 10 computers still work, but they no longer receive normal security updates, feature updates or Microsoft technical support.

There is a temporary safety net: eligible home users can enrol in Microsoft's Extended Security Updates (ESU) programme. This provides important security updates for Windows 10 until 12 October 2027 but does not add new features or provide normal technical support.

If you still use Windows 10, we recommend that you act now. This guide explains the choices in plain language.

Why has Windows 10 support ended?

Windows 10 was released in 2015. Microsoft now wants users to move to Windows 11, which has newer security features and continues to receive regular updates. Windows 11 was first released in 2021 and is updated regularly.

Windows 11 looks a little different from Windows 10, especially the Start menu and taskbar. Most everyday tasks are still familiar. It also includes newer security features and is the version of Windows that current PCs and software are designed to use.

Do I have to move to Windows 11?

No. Your Windows 10 PC will not suddenly stop working. However, using Windows 10 without ESU now carries a greater security risk. If your PC can run Windows 11, upgrading is usually the simplest way to stay supported. If it cannot, consider ESU as a temporary measure or look at replacing the device.

Can I upgrade an older PC safely?

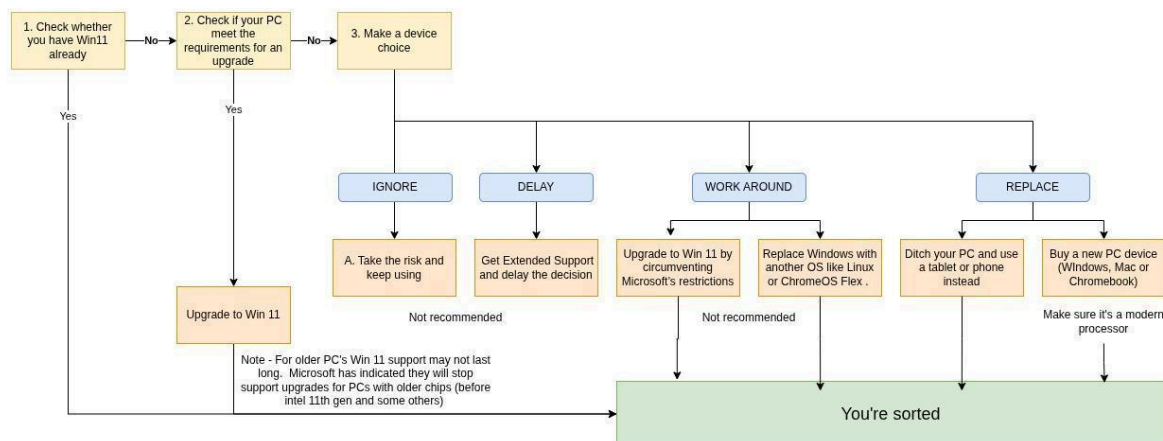
Usually, yes - provided Microsoft says your PC is compatible. Before upgrading, check a few things:

- **Printers and scanners:** Very old printers or scanners may not have Windows 11 drivers. Check the manufacturer's support website for your exact model before upgrading.
- **Older software:** Most common programs work with Windows 11, but some old or specialised programs may not. Check anything that is important to you before upgrading.

- **Performance:** A PC that officially meets the Windows 11 requirements should normally run it well. Avoid forcing Windows 11 onto a PC that Microsoft says is unsupported.

What should I do?

Use the steps below to decide what is right for your computer. More detail follows on the next pages.

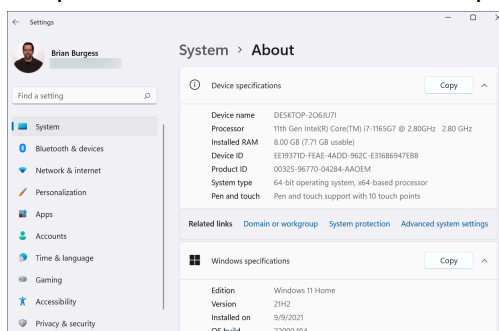


In short: do not ignore the change. If your PC is eligible for Windows 11, upgrade when Windows Update offers it. If it is not eligible, ESU can give you more time until 12 October 2027. You can also replace the PC, or decide whether a tablet, Chromebook or Mac would better suit what you actually use a computer for.

Step-by-Step Guide

1. Check which version of Windows you have

If you already have Windows 11, first make sure Windows Update is keeping it up to date. For most existing PCs, Windows 11 version 25H2 is the current supported feature release. Version 24H2 is still supported for Home and Pro until October 2026, so update to 25H2 when Windows Update offers it.



To check: select Start > Settings > System > About. Look under Windows specifications for the Windows edition and version.

If it says Windows 11, run Windows Update and install the updates Microsoft offers for your PC. You do not need to chase a particular version manually.

If it says Windows 10, continue to Step 2.

2. Check whether your PC can run Windows 11

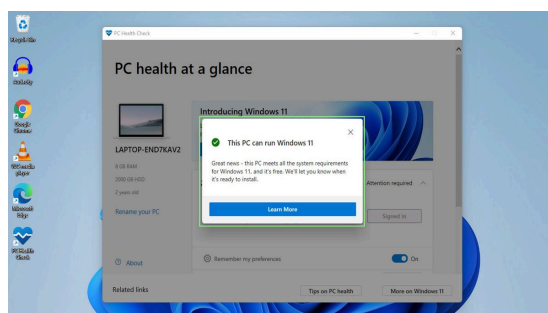
The easiest and safest way to check is to use Microsoft's PC Health Check app. It will tell you whether your computer meets the Windows 11 requirements and, if not, what is preventing the upgrade.

Windows 11 requires, among other things:

- A compatible 64-bit processor with at least two cores
 - At least 4 GB of memory (RAM). In practice, 8 GB or more is more comfortable for everyday use.
 - At least 64 GB of storage
 - TPM 2.0 and a PC capable of Secure Boot - security features found in most newer PCs
- Graphics that support DirectX 12 or later
- A suitable display and internet connection for updates and setup

How to check

On Windows 10, search for PC Health Check from the taskbar. Open it and select Check now under the Windows 11 section. If it is not installed, download it from Microsoft at <https://aka.ms/GetPCHealthCheckApp>.



If PC Health Check says your PC is eligible, you can normally upgrade through Windows Update. Before you start, back up your important files and check that essential printers, scanners and older programs will work with Windows 11.

Go to Start > Settings > Update & Security > Windows Update, select Check for updates, and follow the Windows 11 instructions if the upgrade is offered.

Before you upgrade

A Windows upgrade can take some time and may involve several restarts. Digital Seniors does not normally perform full operating-system upgrades. If you are not confident, ask a trusted technician or experienced helper.

For a normal free upgrade, Microsoft says an eligible Windows 10 PC should be running Windows 10 version 22H2 with current updates installed.

A sensible upgrade checklist is:

1. Before installing
 - a. Back up your important files. Make sure you know where your photos, documents and other important information are stored.
 - b. Check that any important older programs will work with Windows 11.
 - c. Check that your printer, scanner and other important devices have Windows 11 support.
 - d. Install the latest Windows 10 updates before starting.
 - e. Make sure the computer is plugged into power and has enough free storage space.
 - f. If you use device encryption or BitLocker, make sure you can access your recovery key before making major changes.
2. Start the Windows 11 upgrade from Windows Update when it is offered.
3. Follow the on-screen instructions. The computer will restart several times.
4. After installing
 - a. Check that Windows is activated. In most cases activation happens automatically.
 - b. Connect to the internet.
 - c. Run Windows Update again and install any remaining updates.
 - d. Open Microsoft Store and update your apps if needed.
 - e. Check that your printer, scanner, sound, camera and other devices work correctly.
 - f. Take a little time to learn the new Start menu and taskbar.

If PC Health Check says your computer cannot run Windows 11, move to Step 3.

3. Choose your next step

If your PC cannot officially run Windows 11, you still have several choices - replace, ignore, delay or workaround.

3.1. Replace the device

Replacing the computer is often the simplest long-term choice if the current PC is old or unreliable. A replacement does not have to be expensive, and you may not need another full Windows PC at all. There are several good choices:

Use a tablet or phone instead

If you mainly use email, websites, video calls, photos and banking, a current tablet or phone may do everything you need. For banking, use your bank's official app or its genuine website in an up-to-date browser. Never follow banking links from unexpected emails or text messages.

Buy a new Windows 11 PC

This is the easiest choice if you already know Windows or depend on Windows programs. Buy a current model that is officially supported for Windows 11, and let Windows Update keep it current. Avoid very cheap older stock that may have a short remaining support life.

Buy an Apple Mac

A good option for people who already use an iPhone or iPad, although it works differently from Windows. New Macs use Apple silicon (M-series) processors. Don't buy an older Intel-based Mac because Apple is stopping macOS support for these.

3.2. Ignore - Keep using Windows 10 without support

We do not recommend using an unsupported Windows 10 PC for normal internet use. Without security updates, the risk increases over time. This is especially important if the computer contains passwords, personal information or financial records.

3.3. Delay - Use Microsoft Extended Security Updates (ESU) for more time

For eligible home PCs, Microsoft's Consumer ESU programme provides critical and important Windows 10 security updates until 12 October 2027. It is a temporary measure, not a permanent replacement for moving to a supported operating system.

1. ESU provides security updates only. It does not provide new Windows features, general bug fixes or normal Microsoft technical support.
2. To enrol, the PC must be running Windows 10 version 22H2 with the latest updates. The Microsoft account used for enrolment must be an administrator account. You can normally enrol from Settings > Update & Security > Windows Update.
3. Microsoft currently offers three consumer enrolment methods: no additional cost if you sync PC settings using Windows Backup, 1,000 Microsoft Rewards points, or a one-time payment of US\$30 (or local equivalent, plus any applicable tax). An ESU licence can cover up to 10 eligible personal devices linked to the same Microsoft account.

3.4. Workarounds - technical alternatives

There are other ways to keep an older computer useful, but they are best handled by someone with good technical knowledge.

Installing Windows 11 on unsupported hardware

It is possible to bypass some Windows 11 hardware checks, but Microsoft does not recommend installing Windows 11 on a PC that does not meet the minimum requirements. Unsupported PCs may have compatibility problems and are not guaranteed to receive updates. For most seniors, we recommend staying with supported options.

Replacing Windows with another operating system like Linux or ChromeOS Flex

Linux is a free, open-source operating system that can work well on some older computers. It can be secure and well supported when kept up to date, but changing to Linux means learning a different system and some familiar Windows programs may not work. It is best set up with help from an experienced person.

ChromeOS Flex is Google's lightweight operating system for compatible PCs and Macs. It can make some older computers useful for web browsing and other simple tasks. Installing it erases Windows, so files must be backed up first. ChromeOS Flex does not provide the full Google Play Store or normal Android-app support. We suggest getting technical help before changing an existing PC to ChromeOS Flex.

This Information has been checked against Microsoft support and lifecycle information in September 2026. Microsoft may change support dates or programme terms, so check Windows Update or Microsoft Support if you are reading this guide much later.